Narrowing Opportunity Gaps: Enfranchising Socially-Marginalized Students

WHO ARE SOCIALLY MARGINALIZED STUDENTS?

Individuals systematically disenfranchised—i.e., denied rights or opportunities—due to social statuses such as minoritized race, ethnicity, nationality, religion, sex, gender, sexual orientation, and economic status

DISENFRANCHISEMENT INVOLVES:

- Denial of rights, privilege, or opportunity
- Government and school policies and practices facilitate disenfranchisement of students.
- Exclusion, or other treatment as being of lesser importance, of individuals or groups

CONSEQUENCES OF DISENFRANCHISEMENT

- Discrimination has wide-ranging negative effects including physical symptoms, internalizing, externalizing, and post=traumatic stress disorder symptoms, substance use that can in turn reduce school engagement and academic performance
- Intersectionality leads to compounding effects.

RELEVANT SCHOOL POLICIES

Policies for students with:

- Disability,
- Food and housing insecurity,
- English learners,
- Civil rights and antidiscrimination (race, ethnicity, religion, national origin),
- As well as policies related to resource allocation, curriculum, and discipline,
- and intersections thereof as they influence practices related to:
  - Enrollment and attendance
  - Participation in school programming
  - Data-based decision making
  - Curriculum and MTSS
  - Prevention and intervention

School-based mental health professionals should take a **proactive** role in **enfranchising marginalized youth**, bolstering resilience, and reducing inequity by engaging in **culturally responsive** practice and **actively dismantling inequitable policies and procedures**.

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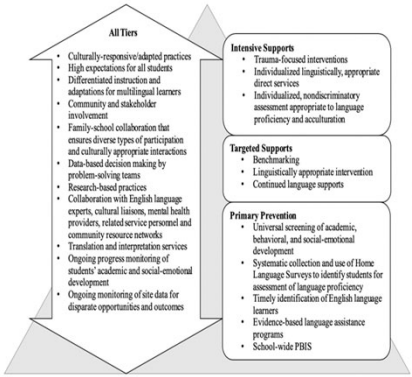


Figure 1. Approaches to enfranchising disenfranchised youth within MTSS. Adapted from Adair (2015); Harris & Sullivan (2017); Sullivan et al. (2018).

HOW SCHOOL PSYCHOLOGISTS CAN FACILITATE ENFRANCHISEMENT

Requires understanding of contextual factors related to opportunity and reduction of opportunity gaps through:

- Proactive cultivation of policies, programs, and supports that remove barriers and support well-being for all.
- Mitigating language barriers for English learners,
- Promoting culturally-responsive practices and culturally-adapted interventions,
- Actively challenging common deficit frameworks and bolstering resilience associated with immigrant advantage, strong cultural/ethnic identity, religiosity, high self-esteem, social support, use of proactive (e.g., confrontation) and passive coping strategies (acceptance), and families' use of racial/ethnic socialization to prepare youth for race/ethnicity-based and discriminatory experiences,
- Mitigating negative impact of immigration policies and climate,
- Supporting consistent enrollment for students who experience housing insecurity,
- Dismantling continued school segregation by race/ethnicity, language, and income.

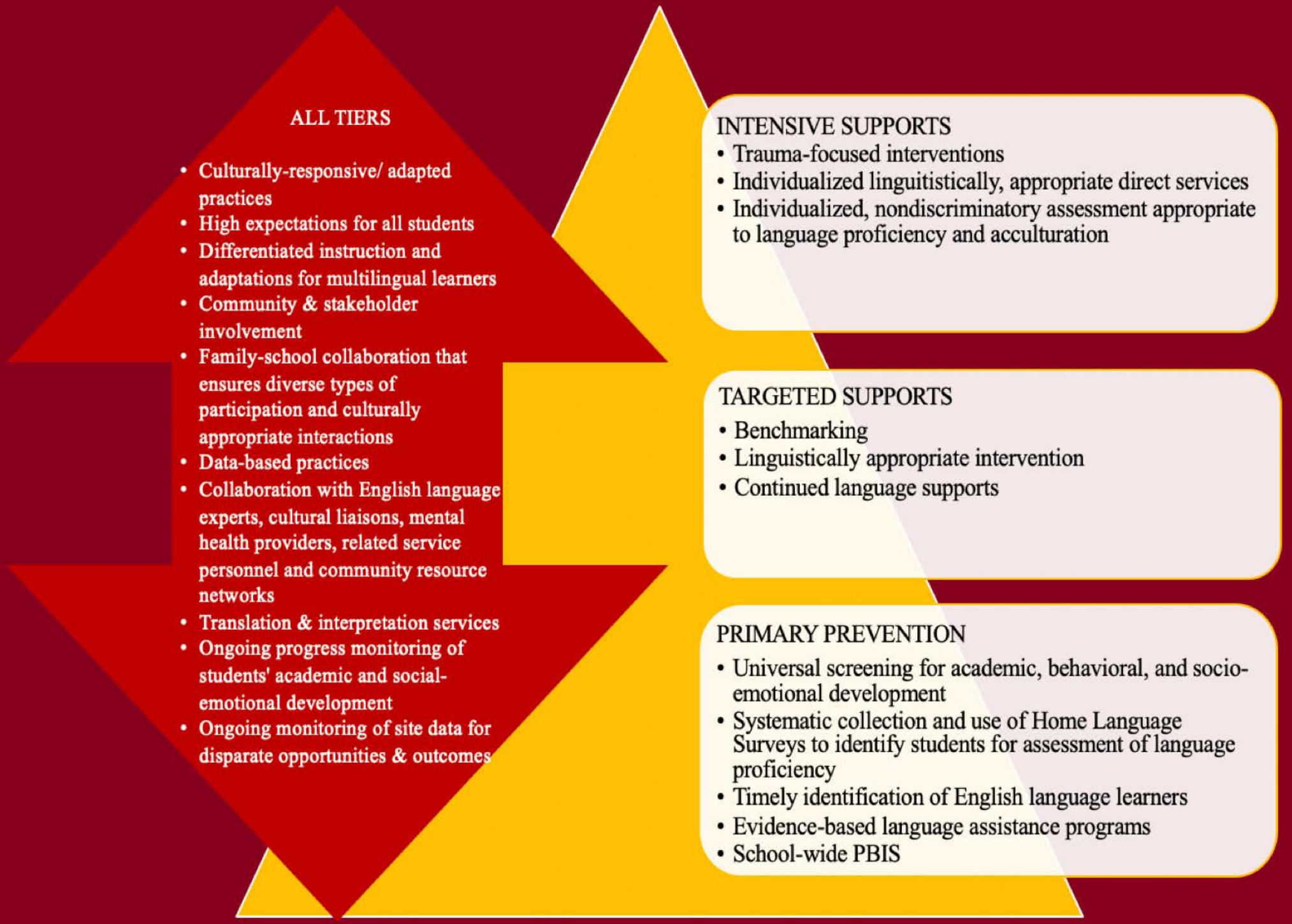


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In Sullivan, A. L., Pham, A., Weeks, M., Nguyen, T. & Dong, Q. (in press). Enfranchising socially marginalized students. In P. Lazarus, S. Suldo, & B. Doll (Eds.), *Fostering the emotional well-being of our youth: A school-based approach*. Oxford University Press.

Text Box 21.1: Ecological Factors Affecting Outcomes and Corresponding Practices

Individual Factors • Personality • Intellectual functioning • Coping strategies • Community and school belongingness • Multilingualism • Religiosity • Ethnic identity • Trauma • Immigration status	*Supportive Approaches* • Foster ethnic identify, self-regulation, coping skills • Support evidence-based language supports • Provide access to research-based instruction, including differentiated instruction • Promote trauma-informed schools and trauma-focused cognitive behavioral therapy • Provide prevention programs to bolster school climate, student engagement, and teacher-student relationships • Develop inclusive policies and procedures to respect and accommodate students' religious observances • Incorporate solution focused therapy
Microsystemic Factors • Socioeconomic status • Parental employment • Parental immigration status • Family cohesion • School resources • Intergenerational relationships and conflict • Neighborhood resources • Residential segregation • Ethnic enclaves • Bias and discrimination • Peer relations and bullying	*Supportive Approaches* • Provide high quality curriculum, instruction, and intervention across full range of developmental domains (see Figure 21.1) • Build positive peer and adult-child relationships • Improve intergroup relations through anti-discrimination and anti-harassment policies; cooperative learning, and practices to bolster empathy and perspective taking • Foster positive, safe school climate for all • Develop culturally-adapted interventions • Provide family outreach and psychoeducation • Ensure open dialogues about issues of difference and equity • Provide explicit support, in policies and procedures, for plurality of social identities and identity expression
Mesosystemic Factors • School connectedness • Family-school engagement • School policies	*Supportive Approaches* • Promote stakeholder involvement • Allow multiple means of family participation • Foster community engagement • Capitalize on students' funds of knowledge
Macrosystemic Factors • Educational policy • Immigration policies and programs • Safety net policies and programs • Cultural attitudes and norms • Biases (e.g., xenophobia, nationalism, Islamophobia, racism) • Segregation by race, language, income	*Supportive Approaches* • Improve intergroup relations • Reduce prejudice, bias, and discrimination • Monitor policies and programs for disparate impact and revise/discontinue as appropriate • Use contextual information and quantitative data to ascertain whether policies and practices are applied equitability • Foster intentionally and proactively involve all stakeholders in evaluation of policies and procedures • Provide ongoing professional learning to ensure awareness of cultural diversity, equity, and nondiscriminatory research-based practice

Adapted from Adair, 2015, APA (2012a, b), Suarez-Orozco et al. (2018), Sullivan, Weeks, Kulkarni, & Goerdt (2018), Walick & Sullivan (2015)